

At 17 I was a party animal! I didn't have a plan and I was uncertain of what to do next. I had just discovered photography and was thinking I could make a living doing that. My stepfather, George, was instrumental in getting me back on track. He convinced me to stay in school and eventually pursue a career as an entrepreneur. To this day, I am grateful for his guidance and for helping me realize I owe my children the same kind of support.

Money Mistake: *You Think You're Too Young to Establish Credit*

The Fix: *Start Building Your Credit Rating at Age 16*

If you think you have to be 18 to start building credit, think again. With rare exception, you can become an authorized user on your parents' credit card at 16. This means you'll be issued your very own card. You'll want to talk it over with them, of course, and you'll need to prove to them that you can be responsible. Think of the next two years as "credit training wheels." Your parents are going to see every purchase you make and hold you accountable for them, and they'll know if you're making payments on time. The second you miss a payment, out come the scissors to slice up your card. Got that?

This arrangement is even better for you if your parents have good credit: your credit rating will improve by association, which will make it easier to qualify for your own separate credit card once you turn 18. Your first credit card lets the rating agencies measure your propensity to pay back your debt on time and on schedule. That's why it's so important to get one: it's how you start building your score.

Your credit score is a number between 300 and 900, where higher is better. Anything over 700 is a pretty good credit score. Every institution has slightly different requirements for what is considered "good credit," but if you keep your score above 700, you'll be safe. If you're under 500, you'll probably have trouble getting a loan. And if your score is closer to 300, no one will give you a line of credit—you're simply not worth the risk, especially for large debt obligations like a mortgage. I know that's quite a ways in the future,